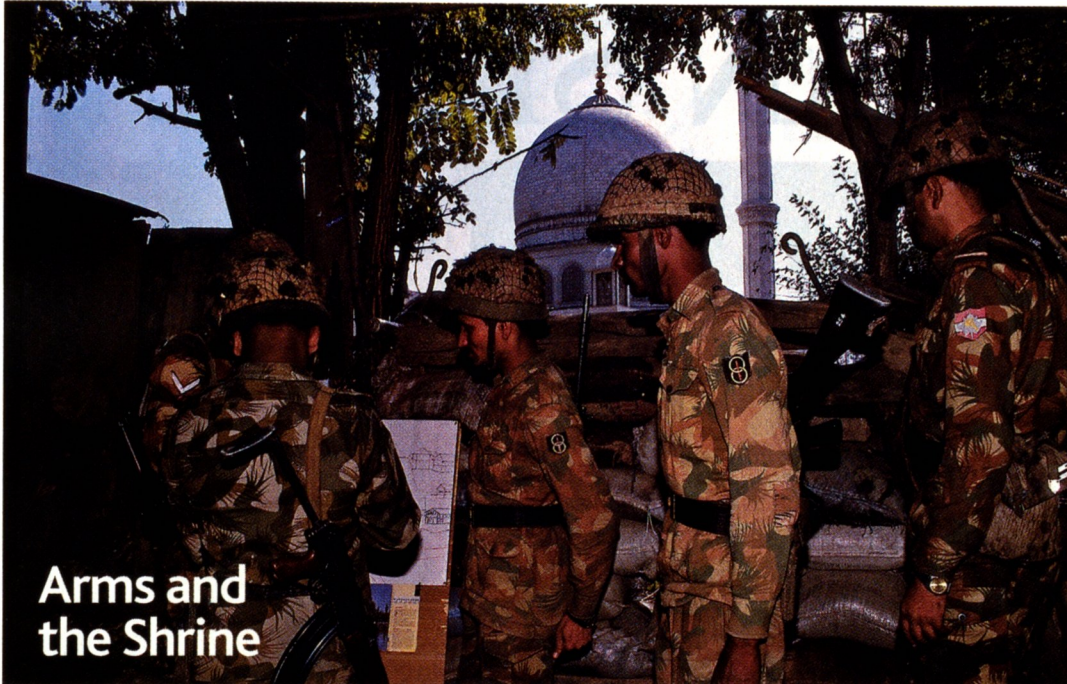


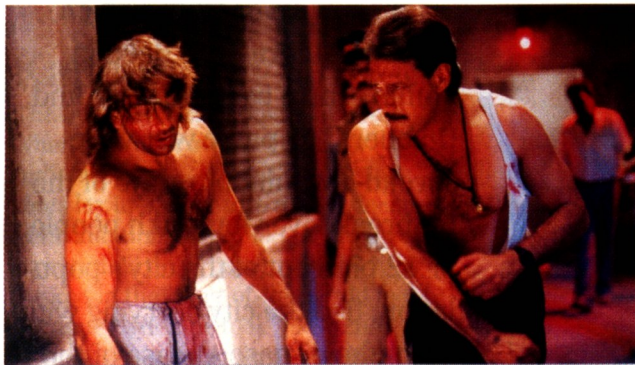
PRAMOD PUSHKARANA



Arms and the Shrine

In April, the army cordoned off a mosque in the Hazratbal area of Srinagar, where 40-50 militants were holed up. But the month-long siege began only on October 15. The government remained indecisive, but in the end, the militants left the shrine "unconditionally".

"NOTHING CAN HAPPEN TO SANJAY NOW." SUNIL DUTT after *Khalnayak's* release



To have a film release with one is playing a terrorist at a time when one is in jail accused of the same is an ironic twist of fate. But for that reason, *Khalnayak*, was remembered more for Ballu Balram, played by Sanjay Dutt than it was for Jackie Shroff or Madhuri Dixit. Subhash Ghai rode the post-*Roja* fascination for terrorism themes to box-office success. And *Choli ke Peeche* helped.

JOLT FROM THE BLUE

The earthquake, which struck Latur and Osmanabad districts of Maharashtra on September 30, measured 6.5 on the Richter Scale. But it made seismic history for other reasons. Its epicentre lay in an area considered the least vulnerable, where one could take comfort in the impossibilities of probability. Yet, when the earth quaked for those three minutes, it left over 15,000 dead and many more homeless. Property worth crores was destroyed.

SHARAD SAXENA



- The Great Blizzard of 1993 struck eastern United States, bringing record snowfall all the way from Cuba to Québec, killing 184.
- A Tamil Tigers suicide bomber assassinated Sri Lankan President Ranasinghe Premadasa.
- In New York City, a van bomb parked below the North Tower of the World Trade Center (below) went off, killing six and leaving over

AP PHOTO



1,000 injured.

- The Maastricht Treaty came into effect, formally establishing the European Union, after protracted talks, and later the euro.

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was India's defence expenditure as a percentage of GDP, compared to China's. India's expenditure is also one-third of Pakistan's in the same measure.